

How to find data

Does the dataset exist?

Evidence a database exists — even before you can download it:

- A form (digital or paper), with a specific title or form number
- An online lookup tool — if you can look up one record, the agency holds all of them
 - MD Board of Physicians license search
 - DC business-license verification
 - VA DPOR licensee lookup
- Published reports & dashboards — summaries of an underlying dataset
- Research by academics — footnotes name datasets, and who already pried them loose

Rule of thumb: if one record is visible, a dataset of all of them usually exists.

Open data portals — not all the same

The platform underneath changes where the Download button lives.

- Washington, DC — opendata.dc.gov
 - Esri / ArcGIS Hub; also “DC Compass,” an AI search over the catalog
- Maryland — opendata.maryland.gov
 - Socrata — same engine as NYC, a useful side-by-side with DC's Esri portal
- New York City — opendata.cityofnewyork.us
 - Socrata
- Whatever the vendor: skip the on-screen table, find Export / Download, grab the CSV
 - Local siblings: dataMontgomery, Open Baltimore, Prince George's County

Where your dataset came from: DC 311

“Finding” and “loading” data are the same pipeline, seen from opposite ends.

1. Resident reports a problem — pothole, dead streetlight, missed trash pickup — by dialing 311
2. The city logs it — each call becomes a row: time-stamped, geocoded, assigned to an agency
3. It's published — the log feeds Open Data DC at opendata.dc.gov
4. You downloaded it — `dc311sample.csv`, the file we've been cleaning in class

This is the “Reported” category, made concrete.

Public records: three jurisdictions, three rulebooks

D.C. FOIA • D.C. Official Code § 2-531 et seq.

- Any person • 15 business days (+10). No central office, so file per agency, or the DC FOIA Portal.

Maryland Public Information Act (PIA) • Md. Gen. Provisions § 4-101 et seq.

- Anyone, no residency rule • ~10 days to respond, up to 30 to produce. It's “PIA,” not “FOIA”; fees can start after 2 hours of work.

Virginia FOIA • Va. Code § 2.2-3700 et seq.

- VA citizens + VA-circulating media only • 5 working days. Out-of-staters can be refused (McBurney v. Young) — file via a Virginia colleague.

A right to records, not to answers. They won't create a record that doesn't already exist.

Filing a request that actually works

- Call before you file - learn the dataset's real internal name & other details
- Ask for it electronically - a spreadsheet or database export, not a scanned PDF
- Limit the time period - 5 years of records is far easier to fill than 50
- Ask for a cost estimate up front and request a public-interest fee waiver

Borrow this language:

“Please provide records in a structured electronic format (CSV, delimited text, or database export), along with any data dictionaries, record layouts, and code sheets.”

The data dictionary is what most people forget, but it can save a lot of time and headache.

When it's not on the portal, that could be a story

What an agency publishes versus what it actually holds can say a lot about that agency's priorities.

DC's own chief data officer has documented datasets that surfaced only after a FOIA request, so not posted on the portal at all:

- Police arrests • dockless scooters • health inspections
- Professional licenses • vacant-property determinations • moving violations

“Missing” data is a finding, not a dead end.

Tools & resources

- **National** — MuckRock (file & track), SPLC Letter Generator, NFOIC sample letters
- **District of Columbia** — Open Data DC (opendata.dc.gov), DC FOIA Portal
- **Maryland** — opendata.maryland.gov, PIA Ombudsman & Compliance Board
- **Virginia** — VA FOIA Advisory Council (free, nonbinding advisory opinions)